

Sunderland roundup as Granit Xhaka relishes 'suffering' and stats suggest huge overperformance

The latest from the Stadium of Light as Sunderland take a break for international fixtures.

[Granit Xhaka](#) has admitted he and his teammates have enjoyed “suffering” for results with [Sunderland](#) at the start of this season.

The Black Cats have returned to the [Premier League](#) with a bang, sitting fourth after 11 games, with 19 points, five wins and just two defeats on the board.

Sunderland have been average as an attacking force, scoring 14 goals so far, with that tally a 2.8 overperformance of their expected goals. At the back, however, only Crystal Palace (9), Manchester City (8) and Arsenal (5) have conceded fewer goals than Sunderland (10) - despite facing the third-most shots (146) and making the second-most clearances (363).

Indeed, Xhaka admits Sunderland have had to work hard for their results so far, but that’s something he and his teammates have relished.

“I used that word because the promoted team has always suffered over the last six or seven years,” Xhaka told Swiss outlet [Blick](#). “We are suffering on the pitch right now, too. It is fun to suffer for the results.

“I give a little speech before most of Sunderland’s matches. It always comes back to the fact that there are two ways to defend: because you have to or because you love it. We love defending.

“That is the difference! That is why we have healthy stability and exceptional balance. Very few teams create chances against us.”

Opta Analyst gives grim Sunderland outlook

Sunderland fans have been basking in the glory of their Premier League form, with the likes of Xhaka, Robin Roefs, and Wilson Isidor putting in sensational performances.

However, according to the stat buffs over at Opta, the Black Cats should count themselves very lucky, with their “expected points” metrics - which is put together using key stats such as chances created and chances conceded - suggesting they should be way down in 15th.

“The teams currently in fourth (Sunderland), fifth (Tottenham) and sixth (Aston Villa) in the Premier League should actually be 15th, 16th and 19th based on the quality and quantity of chances they have created and conceded. The underlying data behind their performances is far worse than their results,” read an article on [The Analyst](#).

“For Sunderland, the xPts table feels unfair. Back in the top flight after promotion last season, Regis Le Bris’ side have been a revelation. Few would contend that they don’t deserve to be where they are in the table.

“A possible explanation for their lowly position in the expected points table is that they spend long periods out of possession. They have averaged 43.2% possession this season and have had as little as 28.6% vs Aston Villa and 31.7% vs Chelsea. When you have that little of the ball and ‘suffer’ as much as Le Bris’ Sunderland, you are more likely to concede chances and ‘lose’ the xG battle.”

The article went on to admit that Sunderland’s play out of possession is exactly what has made them so effective in the top-flight, also highlighting the excellent performances of goalkeeper Roefs.